



International Journal of Sanskrit Research

अनन्ता

ISSN: 2394-7519

IJSR 2025; 11(5): 26-30

© 2025 IJSR

www.anantaajournal.com

Received: 13-07-2025

Accepted: 16-08-2025

Dr. Jyoti Kumari

Assistant Professor & Head
PG Department of Sanskrit,
Rajendra College, Chapra
JPU, Chapra, Bihar, India

Avatarvad in Puranas

Jyoti Kumari

DOI: <https://www.doi.org/10.22271/23947519.2025.v11.i5a.2782>

Abstract

Puranas define Hindu belief of avatarvad- एकम् सद् बहुधा भवति ।

It covers various topics such as history, cosmogony, cosmology, folk tales, pilgrimages, temples, medicine, astronomy, grammar, minerology, humour, love stories, theology and philosophy as well as the genealogies of gods, goddesses, kings, heroes, sages and demigods. Puranas have main five characteristics- Puranam panchlakshanam. Puranas are divided mainly eighteen in numbers. Each purana is peculiar due to incarnation and manifestation of God itself. The main character of the God is well explained in the name of purana itself. All incarnation of the different character of God is mainly Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva accordingly. The Bhagvat Purana is base of Vaishnavism, the tradition dedicated to Vishnu worship and teachings. These Gods manifest themselves to save the humanity and mankind millennium after millennium. One of the most important texts discussing avatars in detail is the Bhagavat Purana. It represents the many avatars focusing on Krishna's life and puranas frequently highlight the ten principal avatars of Vishnu, each of which makes appearance to save the huminity from miscreants. These ten avatars are in form of Dashavatar. During pouranic period the main deities of Hindu is Brahma, Vishnu and Mahesh. Brahma prescribed as sristikarta, Vishnu as sanrakshak and Mahesh as Vinashak. The main puranas are named upon these dieties in many forms or avatara or appearance. The avatara or incarnation mentioned in purana is countless. The Puranas explain metaphysical ideas like creation, destruction, time cycles and reincarnation. Puranas play a significant role in developing different philosophical schools like Vedanta and Bhakti philosophy. Agnipuran gives many chapters on medical issues like medicine, treatment of diseases and even marital science. Ritual healing practices, use of herbs, mantras and purifying methods of soul and body these all things are mentioned in puranas. It is based on the principle of ayurvedic concept. Katthak, Odissi, Bharatnatyam these all dance forms are based on manifestation of God. Krishna Lila in bhagvat purana is atma of all classical dance forms. Detailed description of religion and rituals are found in puranas. Avatarvad in puranas is glimpses of Indian culture and society. The soul concept of avatarvad expands beyond country, religion and time. It is universal truth.

Keyword: Avatarvad, Krishna Lila, cosmogony, cosmology, panchlakshanam, dashavtar, creation, reincarnation

Introduction

Puranas define Hindu belief of avatarvad- एकम् सद् बहुधा भवति । In Bhagvatpurana, there is a verse which describes the concept of avatarvad or incarnation- अवतारा हि असंख्येयया गुणसत्त्वनिधेः द्विजाः। यथा अविदासिनः कुल्याः सरसः स्युः सहस्रशः॥ (श्रीमद्भागवत्) It means that the pond which is filled with water, so many small rivers are originated, like that from almighty God numerous avatara manifested.

This incarnation of Gods is in many forms whether it is living, human, creatures, semi human or God.

Purana is itself very vast in nature. It is called Bhuvan kosha or world encyclopedia. It covers various topics such as history, cosmogony, cosmology, folk tales, pilgrimages, temples, medicine, astronomy, grammar, minerology, humour, love stories, theology and philosophy as well as the genealogies of gods, goddesses, kings, heroes, sages and demigods.

Corresponding Author:

Dr. Jyoti Kumari

Assistant Professor & Head
PG Department of Sanskrit,
Rajendra College, Chapra
JPU, Chapra, Bihar, India

Methodology (Descriptive Method)

Puranas have main five characteristics- Puranam panchlakshanam. It is mentioned within these topics:

सर्गश्च प्रतिसर्गश्च वंशो मन्वन्तराणि च ।
वंशानुचरितं चैव पुराणं पञ्चलक्षणम् ॥

1. Cosmogony
2. Cosmology
3. Genealogy of the gods, sages and kings
4. Cosmic cycles
5. Legends during the times of various kings.

Bhagavat purana expands like this-

1. Karmic links between the deities, sages, kings and living beings
2. Tales about gods
3. Finale or cessation
4. Spiritual liberation or moksha
5. Refuge.

Puranas are divided mainly eighteen in numbers. Each purana is peculiar due to incarnation and manifestation of God itself.

1. Matsya purana
2. markandeya purana
3. Bhavishya purana
4. Bhagavat purana
5. Brahma purana
6. Brahmavaivart purana
7. Brahmanda purana
8. Vayu purana
9. Vishnu purana
10. Varah purana
11. Vaman purana
12. Agni purana
13. Narada purana
14. Padma purana
15. Ling purana
16. Garud purana
17. Kurma purana
18. Skanda purana

The main character of the God is well explained in the name of purana itself. All incarnation of the different character of God is mainly Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva accordingly. These Gods manifest themselves to save the humanity and mankind millennium after millennium- परित्राणाय साधूनां विनाशाय च दुष्कृताम् धर्मसंस्थापनार्थाय संभवामि युगे युगे ॥ (श्रीमद्भगवद्गीता 4।8)

The other type of division of puranas is also described in our oriental text according to the nature of gunas. These are of three types:

1. Sattva or truth- Under this division comes Shiva Purana, Linga purana, Vishnu Purana, Bhagvata Purana, Narada Purana, Garuda Purana, Padma Purana and Varaha Purana-

विष्णुं भागवतं नारदीयं च गरुडकम् ।
पादं वराहं चैव पुराणानि सत्त्वानि तु ॥ (पद्म पुराण)

2. Rajas or Passion- Brahmananda Purana, Brahma Vaivartya Purana, Markandeya Purana and Brahma Purana-

ब्रह्मांडं ब्रह्मवैवर्तं मार्कण्डेयं भविष्यकं ।
वामनं ब्रह्मपुराणं राजसानि प्रकीर्तितम् ॥ (पद्म पुराण)

3. Tamas or Ignorance- Matsya Purana, Kurma Purana, Skanda Purana and Agni Purana-

मतस्यं कूर्मं लिङ्गं शैवं स्कान्दं च निमेव च ।
तामसानि पुराणानि विज्ञेयानि बुधैः सदा ॥ (पद्म पुराण)

Puranas have three types of division as whole-

1. Major
2. Minor
3. Guna or quality based puranas.

Thus, there reflects incarnation or avatara in all types of puranas. Purana is itself all in one in nature-

इतिहासपुराणाभ्यां वेदं समुपबृंहयेत् ।
बिभेति अल्पश्रुताद् वेदो मामयं प्रहरिष्यति ॥

Veda should be explained and supplemented with Itihasa and Purana. The veda fears those of little learning, thinking. This person may misuse me.

During pouranic period the main deities of Hindu is Brahma, Vishnu and Mahesh. Brahma prescribed as sristikarta, Vishnu as sanrakshak and Mahesh as Vinashak. The main puranas are named upon these dieties in many forms or avatara or appearance. The avatara or incarnation mentioned in purana is countless. One of the most important texts discussing avatars in detail is the Bhagavat Purana. It represents the many avatars focusing on Krishna's life and teachings. This Purana is base of Vaishnavism, the tradition dedicated to Vishnu worship.

The puranas frequently highlight the ten principal avatars of Vishnu, each of which makes appearance to save the humanity from miscreants. These ten avatars are in form of Dashavatar-

मच्छछर्गालेऽवतरत् कूर्मो नानावतारः कृतः किल ।
मीनो नृसिंहो वामश्च रामो रामोऽन्यो एव च ॥
कृष्णो बुद्धश्च कल्किश्च दशमे कल्किनामकः ॥ (भागवतपुराण १ . ३ . २५)

1. Matsya(Fish)
2. Kurma(Tortoise)
3. Varaha(Boar)
4. Narasimha(Half Man, Half Lion)
5. Vamana(Dwarf)
6. Parashurama(Warrior with an axe)
7. Rama
8. Balaram
9. Buddha
10. Kalki

As mentioned above that the number of avatara or incarnation is countless, but it is divided into mainly five types-

1. Purusha Avatars- The main appearance of this avatara is related to the cosmic functions of creation, preservation and destruction.
2. Guna avatars- It means the avatara which has embodiments of the three fundamental qualities i.e Sattva, Rajas and Tamas.
3. Leela avatars-These are the manifestations that engage in divine play to delight and instruct devotees.
4. Manvantara avatars- These are the incarnations that appear during the reign of each Manu(a cosmic progenitor).

5. Yuga avatars- Avatars that appear in each yuga (epoch) to guide humanity.

These five divisions can be summarized in two parts

1. Primary incarnations are only ten

The most common type of primary avatars are called Svaroopavatars, in which He manifests Himself in his Sat-chit-ananda form. In the primary avatars such as Narasimha, Rama, Krishna where Vishnu directly descends. Now, Svarupavatara is also of two kinds such as Amsarupavata where Vishnu manifests himself in the person partially. Examples are as follows- From Dashavataras first five avatars Matsya to Vamana except Narasimha are in this category and on the other hand the second type Purnavatara, in which all the qualities and powers of the Lord are expressed. Krishna is expressed as purnaavatara itself. He is almighty god- एते चांशकलाः पुंसः कृष्णस्तु भगवान् स्वयम् । इंद्रारि- वाकुलं लोके मृडयति युगे युगे ॥ (श्रीमद्भागवतपुराण १.३.२८) Narasimha and Rama are also additionally considered to be Lila avatars.

2. Secondary incarnations are several.

Results and Findings

As I mentioned above the feature of puranas encyclopedic texts itself. Arts and culture, philosophy, religion, ethics etc. are the topics which are mentioned as the work of semigods or avatars for the welfare of the mankind.

Philosophy and theology: Indian philosophy is very rich in ideas, beliefs, thinkings and concepts. The Puranas explain metaphysical ideas like creation, destruction, time cycles and reincarnation. Puranas play a significant role in developing different philosophical schools like Vedanta and Bhakti philosophy. In the Padma Purana devotional service defines as pavitram uttamam, the purest service-

अप्रारब्ध-फलं पापं कूटं बीजं फलोन्मुखम् ।

क्रमेण प्रलियेत विष्णु-भक्ति-रतात्मनाम् ॥ (पद्मपुराण, १।१.२३)

For those who are engaged in the devotional service of the Supreme Personality of Godhead, all sinful reactions, whether fructified, in the stock, or in the form of a seed, gradually vanish. Therefore the purifying potency of devotional service is very strong, and it is called pavitram uttamam, the purest.

Medicine (aushadh Vigyan): Agnipuran gives many chapters on medical issues like medicine, treatment of diseases and even marital science- सिद्धौषधानि-अग्निदेवः वसिष्ठः! अहं आयुर्वेदं प्रवक्ष्यामि येन धन्वन्तरिः सुश्रुतम् उपदेशितवान् । (adhyay 279, Verses 1-2) Perfected medicinal formulas- O Vashistha, I shall now speak of Ayurveda, the science of life, as it was taught by Dhanvantari to Susruta.

Garuda purana describes ethics(niti), ayurveda, gemology, astrology and omens.

This portion of Garuda purana describes the fact of courageous sacrifice and discerning association.

Save money for times of distress, but be willing to give it all to save your wife.

It is wise to sacrifice yourself for your family,

Your family for your village, and your village for the country.

Yet, leave a place where people are bigoted, and

Abandon friends who betray. (Garuda purana, purvakanda, chapter 109)

Ritual healing practices, use of herbs, mantras and purifying methods of soul and body these all things are mentioned in puranas. It is based on the principle of ayurvedic concept. Rich source of arts, culture and architecture- Kathak, Odissi, Bharatnatyam these all dance forms are based on manifestation of God. Krishna Lila in bhagvat purana is atman of all classical dance forms. –

कृष्णस्य लीलामृतमेतदात्मनः

पुनाति सर्वान् नृप शुद्धभावान् ।

श्रुत्वानुकीर्त्येति मनोऽमलं यथा

गङ्गाम्भसोम्भोजपवित्रसदनः ॥ (श्रीमद्भागवतम् १२।१२।६८)

Ras panchadhyayi is the soul of bhagvatpurana.

Agnipurana contains references to poetics, literature, drama and music.

Temple construction theory describes in purana. It is also called shilpasashtra or vastusastra-

A shed is erected, with four sacred pits; clay pitchers and bricks are arranged and deities invoked in them. The sacred brick (Angiras's daughter) is placed with invocations, invoking goddess Padmini and energies of Earth, along with offerings- flowers, minerals and weapons of directional deities. (Agnipurana, chapter 41)

These verses cover ritualistic practices prior to temple erection and idol installation.

Religion and Rituals: Detailed description of religion and rituals are found in puranas-

The worship of shivlinga is well described in Shiv Purana-

The Sivalinga is worthy of worship by all gods; It destroys all sins. Worshipped with devotion, it bestows liberation and supreme bliss. (Shiv puran, Vidyeshvara Samhita). Pilgrimage sites or tirthas, holy rivers and temples are well described in puranas. Here is the references for holy rivers to recite in acamana and puja rituals daily-

गङ्गे च यमुने चैव गोदावरि सरस्वति ।

नर्मदे सिंधु कावेरी जलेऽस्मिन् सन्निधिं कुरु ॥

O ganga, Yamuna, Godavari, Sarasvati, narmada, sindhu and kaveri- may you all be present in the water (used for worship) Here is a reference from varah purana on pilgrimage as liberators-

तीर्थानि पुण्यानि सतां निवासाः

सदा पवित्राणि मनोहराणि ।

यत्रामृतं ज्ञानमयं प्रवाह्यं

संसारसिन्धोः परितारकाणि ॥

The holy tirthas are the abodes of the virtuous, always pure and delightful. They are like streams of nectar flowing with divine knowledge, helping souls cross over the ocean of worldly existence.

Method of vratas or vows, danas or charities and yajnas or sacrifices are the sources to glorify gods like Vishnu, Shiva, Devi, Ganesa, Skanda etc. Different type of narratives for these godheads is famous in Indian society.

Culture and Society- Avatarvad in puranas is glimpses of Indian culture and society. Tales of Vishnu, Shiv, Krishna, Ram and Devi Durga is rooted in Indian culture and society.

Navratri, Janmashtami, Ramnavami etc. so many festivals in India are celebrated puranic tradition accordingly.
From Durga kavacham, Markandeya purana nine forms of devi Durga is briefly mentioned-

प्रथमं शैलपुत्री च द्वितीयं ब्रह्मचारिणी ।
तृतीयं चन्द्रघण्टा च कुष्मांडेति चतुर्थकम् ॥
पंचमं स्कंदमाता च षष्ठं कात्यायनेति च ।
सप्तमं कालरात्रिः च महागौरीति च अष्टमम् ॥
नवमं सिद्धिदात्री च नवदुर्गा प्रकीर्तिताः ।
उक्तानि एतानि नामानि ब्रह्मण एव महात्मना ॥

Purana is also called History book (Itihas granth). It preserves legends, genealogies and dynasties. Ethical and moral codes of societies like duties of Varna and ashrama are well written in puranas.

Varna vyavastha is written in Vishnu puran very well-
Brahman dharma-

अध्यापनं अध्ययनं यजनं याजनं तथा ।
दानं प्रतिग्रहोऽध्येषां धर्मो नान्योऽस्ति कश्चन ॥

There are four duties of Brahman- teaching and learning, performing sacrifices and officiating at sacrifices and giving and receiving gifts.

क्षत्रिय धर्म (kshatriya dharma)
प्रजानां परिपालनं दण्डधारणमेव च ।
दानं च यजनं चैव स्वधर्मोऽयं यदीश्वर ॥

Kshatriya dharma is for protecting the people, for justice and punishment and for giving gifts and performing sacrifices.

वैश्य धर्मः (Vaishya dharma)-

Agriculture, tending cattle, trade and giving gifts these are the duties for merchant or farmer.

कृषिगौरक्ष्यवाणिज्यं दानं चान्यन्यथा न हि ।
धर्म एष समासेन वैश्यस्य परिकीर्तितः ॥
शूद्र धर्मः (Shudra dharm)
एकमेव तु शूद्रस्य प्रभुः कर्म समादिशत् ।
एतेषामेव वर्णानां सेवा धर्मः सनातनः ॥

The supreme duty prescribed is service to the other three varnas.

Detailed subscription of ashrama vyavastha is found in Vishnu Purana (3.9.1-3) also.

Brahmacharya ashrama-

ब्रह्मचारी गुरुं सेवेत दांतो मौनी जितेंद्रियः ।
स्वाध्यायनिरतः शुद्धो वेदव्रतपरो द्विजः ॥

The student life is the base of the four stages. During this stage student should serve the teacher with self control, silence and mastery over the senses and should be devoted to study, pure in conduct and faithful to the vows of the Veda.

Grihastha ashrama-

ऋतुकाले समभिगच्छेत् धर्मपत्नीं यथाविधि ।
गार्हस्थ्ये धर्मनिष्ठः स्यात् सत्यव्रतपरायणः ॥

At the proper time, he should approach his lawful wife according to prescribed rites; he should uphold dharma in household life, devoted to truth and righteous vows.
Vanprastha ashrama-

वने वसेन्मिताहारो दांतः सत्यपरायणः ।
हविष्याशी जितक्रोधो लोभमोहविवर्जितः ॥

He should dwell in the forest, taking limited food, self restrained, devoted to truth; living on sacrificial food, free from anger, greed and delusion.

Sanyas ashrama-

संयस्य सर्वकर्माणि निरपेक्षो निराश्रयः ।
आत्मज्ञानरतः शुद्धो मोक्षधर्मे व्यवस्थितः ॥

Renouncing all actions, without dependence or expectation, devoted to self knowledge, pure and established in the dharma of liberation (moksha)

Cosmology and Science: Creation, dissolution and recreation of the world can be seen in puranic avatarvad. Descriptions of mountains, rivers, continents like meru parvat, Jambudvip, aaryavart etc. are well located in puranas.

The description of panchmahabhut is found in Bhagvat purana (3.26.11)

आकाशात् सम्भवो वायोः वायोरग्निस्ततो अभवत् ।
अग्नेरापः पृथिव्याः स्यात् सर्वभूतात्मकं यतः ॥

From ether arose air, from air came fire;
From fire came water and from water the earth;
Thus are all beings composed.

The cosmology like a virat purush as a symbolic expression is compared in bhagvat purana (5.23.3)

चंद्रमाः मनसो जातः चक्षोः सूर्यः अजायत ।
दिशः श्रोत्रात् तथा वायुः प्राणाद् वाचोऽभिजायत ॥

The moon was born from the mind, the Sun from the eyes;
Directions came from the ears, and Air from the breath.
Different dimensions of science in ancient India like astronomy and time cycles are found in puran. Mahayuga, manvantara and kalp are termed for time cycles.

Genealogy and History: Descriptions of genealogies of gods, sages, kings and dynasties are well defined in puranas. It is also sankalan granth of ancient Indian history.

Here are the examples of purana which is related to genealogy and history-

वंशानुचरितं पुण्यं शृणुयाद्यः समाहितः ।
स पाप्मनां विमुच्येत विष्णुलोके महीयते ॥ (विष्णु पुराण ४ . २४ . १०३)
इतिहासपुराणानि पंचमं वेदमिष्यते ।
सात्वतं प्राहुरेवैतद्भगवान्नारदस्य च ॥ (भागवत पुराण १ . ४ . २०)

Thus, manifestation or incarnation of God in different forms defined in puranas projects the all type of knowledges which is essential for our existence.

The tradition of Dashavatara shows the different era of incarnation. These incarnations span Dharma and destruction of adharma. This Avatarvad reflects so many characteristics itself. It is based on the doctrine of devine play(lilavad). The

purpose of avatarvad is to establish righteousness and to remove evil.

It is also significant for historical and cultural dimension. It is not only religious narrative but also reflects cultural ideas. For instance, Ram and Krishna both indicates religious importance as well as historical feature. Rama is seen as an ideal king and Krishna as the divine teacher and friend.

Avatarvad in purana deals with foundation of bhakti or devotion. Narratives of Rama and Krishna in the puranas inspired with devotional movement.

The concept of incarnation is more relevant in the modern era. The narratives of Ram, Krishna, Shiv, Vishnu, Durga give the inspiration of religious, social and moral movements. It gives the symbolic representation of great leaders. Gandhiji is called Yug purush as manifestation of great human being.

The concept of avatarvad is for the welfare of humanity. This is universal truth. It affirms that God is not distant but intimately concerned with human welfare. That's why it is relevant for modern era. The relation between religion and politics depends on the rights and duties given by the states to upgrade the society. Ramkrishna paramahansa and Vivekananda are the yug purush of 21st century.

National movement, bhakti movement, environmental awareness, sustainable development all these areas are affected from positive narratives. These narratives are inspired by pauranic granth which deal with wellness of whole ecosystem.

Modern world is digital world. Media, cinema and all entertainment tools are digitalised. Now a day there is a trained developed to play all avatars digitally. It is in animation or live cinema. It gives great impact on new generation in growing oneself with our ancient culture and religion.

The concept of avatarvad in purana plays a key role to introduce relation between Science and Religion. Modern scholars believe in avatars as vital source of understanding human revolution-

उद्धरेदात्मनाऽत्मानं नात्मानमवसादयेत् ।

आत्मैव ह्यात्मनो बंधुरात्मैव रिपुरात्मनः॥ (भगवद्गीता ६ .५)

One must elevate oneself by one's own mind, not degrade oneself. For the self alone is one's friend, and the self alone is one's enemy.

The real human revolution begins in recognizing oneself. It is possible by transforming one's own mind and character.

Conclusion

The essence of this topic lies into the featuring of avatars or incarnations as a whole dimensional value of life. It is in the form of ethics, philosophy, religion, art and culture, social life, mythology and cosmology. The God manifests Himself millennium after millennium for the sake of mankind-

परित्राणाय साधूनां विनाशाय च दुष्कृताम् ।

धर्मसंस्थापनार्थाय संभवामि युगे युगे ॥ (श्रीमद्भगवद्गीता ४ .८)

Whenever and wherever dharma declines, the Lord manifests Himself again and again.

This philosophy is for today's world also. The core of the avatarvad deeply rooted in purana but it continues for everlasting. The soul concept of avatarvad expands beyond country, religion and time. It is universal truth.

References

1. Bhagvatpuran
2. Padmapuran
3. Lingpuran
4. Skandpuran
5. Srimadbhagvadgita
6. Sanskrit sahitya ka Itihas- Baldeo Upadhyay
7. Gadur Puran
8. Markandey Puran